

software, and what we can do to stop the unethical ways. They don't say that proprietary software is an injustice. They say that it is convenient for you to let users change and redistribute the software you release, because then they will improve the code quality. This, I disagree with.

Q Why does a free program have a licence? Licences are for proprietary programs and their purpose is to restrict people, right?

For us, it is the opposite. A Free Software licence is actually a statement of permission that gives the users the four freedoms. That's the only way a program or any other kind of work can be free, if the copyright holders have put this on the statement of permission. This is because under today's copyright law, whatever work is done is under copyright. By default, copyright law forbids users to copy software, change it, distribute it—and many countries even forbid running it, because it is copying into main memory. So, the only way a program can be 'free' is through a formal declaration by the copyright holders, giving every user the four freedoms. We term that declaration a Free Software licence. If a work does not have that licence, it is not free. And there are people who are publishing things and saying these are free, but they don't put on the licences, so what they are saying is false. When you see this, you should complain to them, and say, "I am glad you would like it to be free, but you actually legally need to make it free—so please do that!"

There are many ways to give people the four freedoms, and that is why there are many Free Software licences. The big difference between Free Software licences is between the copyleft licences and the non-copyleft licences. The GNU General Public License is a copyleft licence. It means that it requires the distribution (with or without changes) be under the same licence. In effect, it says, you can distribute this code to others, but you must respect their freedom the same way we respect your freedom. Looking at the same thing from a different point of view, it means that the man who provided a software copy to you must respect your freedom the same way he took advantage of the freedom given to him. Without copyleft, one person or one company can get a copy of the program as Free Software, and put on restrictions, and distribute it to you as proprietary software. And then the freedom, which is the purpose of this law, will not reach you. This would be a failure for the GNU system, according to the Free Software Movement, because the reason we developed the GNU system is to ensure you have freedom. If this freedom is taken away by a middleman, we fail. So I invented the idea of copyleft as a way to prevent that failure. And that's why I wrote the GNU General Public License, as the way to release software—but I wrote it so that everyone else could also release their software that way.

So, when Torvalds decided to make Linux free software in 1992, he used the GNU General Public License to do that.



The GNU GPL is not the only Free Software licence; there are non-GNU Free Software licences as well. But because the GNU GPL is a copyleft licence, it's usually better, because why let somebody else have the chance to deny freedom to some of the users of your copy?

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Q Don't you think you could run the Free Software Movement if you write more programs?

No. That's not true. That was true at the beginning because in the 1980s (during the early days), the free software I wrote was a substantial part of the Free Software Movement. But nowadays, the Free Software community is so big, and there are so many software, that my additions would constitute a tiny portion of it. And besides, I am older now. I cannot do that as well as I used to. Meanwhile, what I see is that there is a terrible lack of valuing freedom, and this is not being addressed by people so much—so that is where I need to contribute.

RMS on Indian developers

Q Based on your interactions with the community in India, what are your observations about the Free Software Movement in India?

Well, there are a few activists who have campaigned strongly for Free Software, and they have had some successes. Some of the schools in Kerala switched to free software—but most of the Free Software community is not thinking about freedom, and there are obstacles from